defence treaty, which directed the signatories to extend military support to any member state in case of an attack by Germany or any third party in Europe. Undoubtedly, it implied the threat coming from the Soviet Union.

In protest to this Brussels Pact, in March 1948 the Soviet representatives withdrew from the Allied Control Council, which was the governing body of occupied Germany. But now the Cold War tensions started over Germany. This, coupled with the creation of West Germany in early June 1948 and the introduction of a separate currency, the Deutsche mark, in the French, US and British zones resulted in a strong Soviet response in the form of the **Berlin Blockade** in the same year. The United States to beat the Soviet blockade, which continued for 324 days had to airlift 13,000 tonnes of supplies of food per day.[7] Finally, the blockade was lifted but it increased rivalries and suspicions among the two superpowers. The Berlin Blockade also led to the militarization of Europe resulting in the formation of a military alliance—North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), 4 April, 1949—to counter Soviet expansionist designs.

1949–1953

In the late 1940s, the theatre of Cold War shifted to Asia. Around this time China became an important factor in the superpower relations. The Korean War also dragged the superpowers to this region.

The formation of the Peoples Republic of China by the Chinese communists under the leadership of Mao-Tse-Tung and the defeat of the Chinese Nationalists (Kuomintang) under General Chiang Kai-shek were seen with great apprehension by the Western powers. They perceived the rise of China as a part of an ‘ascendant monolithic communist bloc’. Therefore, the vision of global expansion of communism deeply influenced the US foreign policy.

The Korean War of 1950 further brought the two superpowers into confrontation, if not directly, and embittered the relationship between the two. North Korea under Kim II Sung, the leader of North Korean Communist Party, wanted to unite the peninsula which South Korea proceeded to proclaim as the Korean Republic. Therefore, the stage